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Don Wolff

Don Wolff has become one of the leading authorities of jazz on film. A lawyer by trade, his love of jazz has led to a weekly radio show for KMOX that covers most of the country every Saturday. Don has amassed one of the largest collections of jazz on film in the U.S. He is a frequent guest at festivals and jazz parties where he shares his film clips and considerable knowledge about jazz personalities and the history of this American art form.

Don was interviewed by Monk Rowe at the Sarasota Jazz Festival on April 13, 1996.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. My name is Monk Rowe, and it's a pleasure today to have Don Wolff, producer of a great radio series for KMOX, down here in Sarasota, Florida, and general keeper of the jazz flame. And I'm really interested how this all came about and that presentation you gave on Basie was really marvelous.

DW: Thank you. Well it's a hobby. I'm a lawyer in my spare time.

MR: In your spare time.

DW: A criminal defense lawyer, who happens to love jazz. And I started just collecting when video recorders came out. I had been a jazz collector long before that with records, but I became interested in preserving jazz on film. I had one of the first home recorders and one of the early cameras, and I went from 3/4 inch to Beta, being one of the smart people that knew Beta would be the format to survive, and then eventually VHS and I'm into laser disks. And I collect and trade with people all over the world so it's an interesting hobby and I love putting the shows together, whether it's for a jazz festival or for teaching colleges or courses back home in St. Louis.

MR: It's a great resource to be able to see and hear the music at the same time. One thing that we sometimes forget is we look at the players now and from that era of course they're in their 70s and 80s, and we forget that they were young men when they were producing all this great music.

DW: Well you know it's interesting from lots of perspectives, that's one of them for certain. Also just the film industry as well as jazz on film has a certain attraction to me as an interesting part of American history. Sad in some ways, nonetheless an important part of our archival history, so I'm happy to have collected it and I love to share it because it's one thing to listen to the music and talk about the music, but as you say, it's another thing to see the music and hear it at the same time.

MR: I was interested in your comment when you said in order to get Basie in Hollywood we had to see some of the kind of bad Hollywood too.

DW: Well that's particularly true for African American musicians who didn't get the opportunity that white musicians got in the early part of the Hollywood history. So when we got jazz, that was one thing on film, it was another thing when we got African American jazz on film. And you see some of our great American musicians relegated to the roles that not only Hollywood placed on them, but all of America placed on them. So that was real sad to see Billie Holiday only as a maid, and Louis Armstrong only as a butler, and the only person Louis Armstrong could have a love relationship with in a movie was a horse. In those days African Americans weren't allowed to express emotion to one another, to people.

MR: I've read some really questionable things about a couple of filmings where if there was a white musician in the band they had to blacken his skin or vice versa.

DW: The very first film of a jazz musician was a Duke Ellington film. And you are exactly correct. That's what they did in one of the Ellington films is had to darken one of the musicians with a blackface so that he would be blacker on film than he was in real life. Even though he was an African American.

MR: Oh, was this, I'm trying to remember, was it the saxophone player?

DW: Yes it was the saxophone player as I recall and I think the name of the movie was, well it was one of the first Ellington short films. It was a nine minute short film, "Black and Blue" or something like that or "Bundle of Blues."

MR: When you see the — I don't know if demographics is the right word — but the audience that comes to these festivals, which is great, it's a great turnout. But when you see that it's ninety-five percent white and does that bother you?

DW: It bothers me tremendously. Generally when I see ninety-five percent white attendees it's because there is also a ninety-five percent white participant level. I came from a festival not too long ago which did not have one African American and that's despicable in this day and age. I'm not too happy about the reverse of that either. And there are those now who in order to get even are only putting on African American type productions, and I just believe that jazz is an American original art form music. And I give African Americans a great deal of credit for the birth of jazz and for historically keeping jazz alive, and I think they deserve that. On the other hand I don't think the music belongs to white or black, it belongs to all of us and we ought to keep it American and not have it split along racial lines.

MR: Yeah. It really doesn't pay the proper respect to the music to divide it like that.

DW: No. But this festival here has a great deal of balance racially speaking, and jazz cruises you'll find a good balance not only of the musicians but of the attendees when I have seen roughly forty-five to fifty percent levels.

MR: Is Basie is personal favorite of yours?

DW: Well Ellington is number one. I think Duke Ellington, well you heard Basie in the films yesterday agree with that comment. I think Basie, and I met Count Basie a number of times personally. I think on a personal level he was the most genuine. He was the nicest. Success never went to the head of Bill Basie. He was the same, I think, when he was getting started with Bennie Moten and probably didn't have two nickels to rub together, as in the latter part of his life when he was a very wealthy, successful man. It just didn't go to his head. He didn't get what we in the legal profession call "phrentolitis." Perhaps that can't be said for lots of others. But when I think of American original art form music, Duke Ellington is at the top of my list. Count Basie certainly isn't far behind.

MR: Right. Who is a better American composer than Duke Ellington?

DW: Nobody, in my opinion.

MR: It's so interesting to watch the audience at your little presentations there, and we see a face and you say now who is that? And people just love to zero in on these personalities.

DW: Well you know you're torn when you put these shows on. Do you want to continuously talk through the movie, or do you want to let the people enjoy the films? And I have always chosen the latter of those two courses, the most consistent criticism I get is that I should talk more often. I think that's a better criticism than you talk too much.

MR: Right. Because when you know these little great anecdotes about people, you constantly want to say, "Now this fella here—" and it's very hard not to talk.

DW: If I could just make the films shorter and leave more time for talking when the films weren't being shown, I might be able to reach a balance. But what happens is if I get an hour to do a film, like I had for yesterday, the film was an hour and thirteen minutes long. I didn't know what to cut.

MR: Well you've amassed quite a collection of films. How many, do you have a number of films that you have now?

DW: No. No more than I have a number of 33s that I have. I think when you collect you don't want to get into numbers. I don't put a dollar value on it, I have no idea how much I have. What I do know is that it is one of the largest in the world and I share with people all over the world, other collectors. And I'm kind of proud to say that I feel the collection is there to be shared not to be hoarded and not to be kept private, so it is something that I've really enjoyed and that I like to think I help other people enjoy as well.

MR: Can you tell me a little more about your radio work?

DW: Yeah. I'm real thrilled with the show I'm doing right now which is a four hour jazz show on KMOX which is a 50,000 clear channel watt station, it reaches some 48 states. I get phone calls from all over the country and Canada every Saturday night. It's a very powerful midwestern station which also is the sports voice of St. Louis so we have the Cardinals which reach a great many homes, and I come on after the ball game. We have

the blues and so it's a sports station and it's a talk radio station, and one of the few AM stations that's really survived in a marketplace that they've become relics. But this particular station is quite successful and they allow me to bring in my own music, I've never been told that I can't play this or I can't play that, so I have total freedom and independence in what I do and so I design my programs as if I'm the listener. And I figure that if I'm going to enjoy the music, chances are my listeners will too. But I've got to enjoy it first or I don't put it on. So when I get calls for Lawrence Welk, he doesn't make my show.

MR: I guess you can only go by your own tastes and your own likes, you know you can't second guess your audience.

DW: Well I view the audience as really one who is interested in the music for a number of reasons, not the least of which I hope is to learn a little bit more about the music. So I use the four hour show as really a teaching tool. And I really think that's what gives me the most pleasure, the fact that I enjoy the music that goes along with it makes it even that much more fun. But I'm getting an opportunity not only to share music I love, but to teach other people how to appreciate it. That's a good feeling.

MR: Have you been a fan of this music since you were growing up?

DW: Yes. I was a product of the era when everybody else went to Elvis and the Beatles. And I stayed with the big bands, and I stayed with Ellington and Basie and I never moved off of mainstream jazz. Rhythm and melody. I really like the standards. Even the new jazz is really not so much my preference as it is to hear a Gershwin or a Berlin or an Ellington or a Basie tune and hear it done the original way as well as hearing it done today. And I do a lot of that. I call it mixing and matching. Doing the same song done by two different groups or the same performer early in the career and late in the career — nothing more enjoyable than listening to Billie Holiday at the beginning of her career and at the end of her career and listening to the difference in the sounds and the feeling that the woman had during her lifetime.

MR: I've often wondered if we are writing, since the '40s especially, is anybody writing standards since then you know? In fact Herbie Hancock just came out with a record and I forget the exact title of it, but what he did was he found what he thought were going to be the standards to come. And he did some more modern tunes but treated them as jazz tunes I guess.

DW: Well I think those probably will be standards for our children and maybe our grand-children, but I think for me, certainly for me personally as well as for me collectively, the Tin Pan Alley songs are what America is all about. Those will always be loved songs because they're just part of America.

MR: I think too that the craft that it took to sit at a piano and write those tunes, when you have technology into the mix these days, sometimes you tend to depend too much on the technology and perhaps the chord structures don't have to be as sophisticated because you have this interesting drum sound from a machine. I think there is great songs written today but the focus is a little different.

DW: It is indeed and I think the audience will change as this audience today gets older. We may see people today enjoying a kind of music that you and I aren't turned on to. I think these are the very same people who five, ten years from now will enjoy the kind of music we enjoy today. So I think it's a question sometimes of growing up and maturity as well as exposure.

MR: What's going to happen to — I don't know if you'll have an answer to this — it's just, thinking ahead fifteen years from now at the Sarasota Jazz Festival, what kind of musicians will they be featuring?

DW: Well who knows? The Sarasota Jazz Festival I've always felt has its finger more on the pulse than many of the others. I go to jazz festivals that have only Dixieland and unfortunately only white Dixieland. Well that may be okay for the couple of thousand people that enjoy that kind of music. That's not what I think music or even jazz is all about. But the Sarasota Jazz Festival really is pretty progressive. Christian McBride. When you have a Christian McBride at a festival like this, even I, who think I know a lot about the music, learned how much more to enjoy and appreciate him and his group after listening to him in person last night. It was the first time I had listened to him. I was turned on much more than when I played his CD previously. So I'm going to go back home with a renewed interest in wanting to hear more of Christian McBride and his wonderful trio. His whole group, all three of the other players with him were wonderful.

MR: I think that was a good call for them to do. And people liked it. I don't know if everybody liked it, but he certainly had people afterwards saying how much they enjoyed his work and we were able to speak with him after the concert and he was saying, "You know when I got out there, I was a little worried, looking at the audience." But I think for one thing they responded to the fact that he presents himself so well and he involves people in the music, and I always felt that that's an important thing to do for a musician is speak to the audience and get them on your side.

DW: This is a very scary audience, this Sarasota audience. First of all the average age is a good deal higher than most other audiences. And I think the people are much more conservative. So you have to be willing to take a risk to bring a group like that here. But the Sarasota festival has traditionally done that. Others that I've been to, festivals that have come and gone, didn't take that risk. They got into a format, they stayed with that format until the people got tired of coming, and that was the end of the festival.

MR: I have to comment on your comment about Dixieland and that the groups that are playing Dixieland now, something has changed from the original, I mean which of course will happen, but it seems to be to me a little bombastic most of the time, and overdone.

DW: Well I think they saturate you with it. It isn't like you can go to a concert and hear one or two Dixieland tunes. You go to one of these kinds of festivals, and that's all you hear. I don't mind that if you're going to go to a Bix Beiderbecke memorial concert, then you can hear all that kind of music. On the other hand if I go to a jazz festival quote unquote, I don't want it to be all of anything because jazz is too broad a spectrum. And I do think that the African Americans who have moved away from that kind of music for one reason or another and some of those reasons are very good, some of them I may not agree with. But the fact is they've moved away from that music, which is traditionally and historically their music. And now to see that kind of music only played by white musicians and has a bit of a racial overtone to it, that turns me off.

MR: I agree. And when I look at the folks that are playing/producing for lack of a better term classic jazz now, it seems to be almost all white musicians on the labels I see. And I wonder why that is. But I sound like I'm complaining too much.

DW: Well I saw the Preservation Hall Jazz Band just recently. And interesting that that band is not an example of what we're talking about. Either what you or I have said, the exception is the Preservation Hall Jazz Band. Number one they're still mostly African Americans in the band and number two, they have both the very, very old and the very, very young — some wonderful young players, African American, are in that band. So I'm glad that there's one exception.

MR: How is your archive of films for Joe Williams?

DW: I have a wonderful — I'm a particular fan of Joe's, both professionally and personally. I've seen him so many times in recent years, particularly on the jazz cruises, one of his favorite places to perform. So I've been a collector of Joe Williams for some time, and I think I have a pretty wide collection, given that I'm in the midwest and Joe performs almost exclusively on the west coast or else in New York. And he's pretty well into retirement. He says he's retired, he's really not, he still performs a great deal on the west coast. But his price for going out on the road is prohibitive, although we've tried many times to bring him to St. Louis, we can't afford him. We can't afford that kind of a price, particularly for a charitable event. But on film there's a wealth of film on Joe Williams and you got to see a bit of it yesterday, particularly some rare clips when he was very young and just starting out with Count Basie.

MR: And his stage persona changed somewhat.

DW: Oh, a great deal. Well Joe is so comfortable with himself right now, I mean he has a degree of not only self confidence but he is just in a good place in his life for him. He's

living life and enjoying it, he's happy, and he's happily married with his wife of many years, and he's just in a really good place. And when you see him tonight and you hear him tonight you're going to feel that. He communicates that. I'm okay you know, I'm all right.

MR: Marvelous. What effect did the dancing that was so connected with jazz, and at the end of World War II I guess, do you have a take on what kind of happened at that point?

DW: Well a number of things happened. Number one America got out of the dance phase quote unquote. The art of dance was very, very important both to jazz and vice versa. Not only in Hollywood, but in the early days of jazz, jazz was associated with dancing. Even Glenn Miller quote unquote jazz. The people when they really got to enjoying Glenn Miller and Benny Goodman, jitterbugged. So it wasn't just music to crowd around the bandstand and listen to, it was music to dance to and the same thing was true with Ellington and Basie. But I think after the war, people stopped dancing as much as they did before. For some reason or another, the craze, the dance craze sort of disappeared from the face of America. Whether it was because it was a time of less pleasure and more work and more need to generate income and the cost of entertainment was a questionable item or not, an economic reason or not, I'm not sure. But when you look back at the period you see that the jitterbug phase and the dancing to jazz faded out right shortly after the war, World War II.

MR: I sometimes wonder if there wasn't enough stress after World War II. I mean the dancing could have been a release because there were tough times and there was a war and all that, and when that went away, maybe people didn't feel that need to—

DW: Well you know the big bands disappeared — certainly were reduced in number and popularity and economically they didn't survive, only a few of the big bands survived. So as the big band sound disappeared, so did the dancing that went with the big bands. Now we got all kinds of other dancing that came in but it's not associated with jazz. And I remember when the twist came in and the limbo came in, and although that wasn't jazz, you know, it wasn't far off from jazz and of course jazz has gone off into Brazilian and South American trends. And there is some dancing that goes on with that kind of music.

MR: One of the musicians we talked to seemed to sum up the whole thing he said well music switched from swing eighth notes to even eighth notes. And that just about said it all. Because even eighth notes became rock & roll.

DW: From a musician's point of view that was a good answer.

MR: I was so interested to see the clip you had of Basie's small group. I had not seen that.

DW: Really? Oh it's one of my favorite clips. There is actually about six or seven, maybe eight of those particular numbers performed by that group. Some with Freddie Green and Helen Humes the singer, who sang with them at that time. I can't recall, I don't believe

any other singers sang with that particular group. Interesting about that also, getting back to the racial, there was a story that Buddy DeFranco, who appeared on film in some of the showings was not on the soundtrack, that it was dubbed in by Marshall — his first name is not coming to me. But the sound of Buddy DeFranco was eliminated because in the south they didn't want white mixing with black so the white music was — Marshall Royal.

MR: But they let him stay in the film?

DW: But in the south they did a lot of pairing of films that had black and whites. So you not only had darkened faces, there were sometimes Ellington and members of Ellington's band were removed. I think "Check and Double Check" was an example of the blackening of faces also which was one of the first feature films where an African American musical group appeared. But I did read in one of the Basie books that for certain purposes, the sound of Buddy DeFranco was removed and replaced with Marshall Royal on the film you saw yesterday. But it is, there are some wonderful clips and you get to see a little of all the people and that's some rare film of Wardell Gray that rarely do you get a chance to see Wardell Gray on film.

MR: Yeah. He died fairly young, didn't he?

DW: Yes.

MR: I'm quite impressed usually by the balance of the sound. The sound itself is dated, but you can hear everything, which sometimes really amazes me. Like what technology did they have back then, did they just hang a microphone and they let the band balance themselves perhaps?

DW: Well some of our greatest treasures come from people using little microphones and recording at concerts. But that particular session was well recorded. I never have any problems with the sound, but it depends on what kind of equipment you have to show it on and yesterday we had some wonderful equipment so you got to hear the sound that I hear at home, which is not often the case when I'm showing these kinds of films. Because if you don't have good sound equipment, you don't get the kind of sound you heard yesterday.

MR: Did you have an era, returning to Ellington for a moment, the favorite Ellington band for you?

DW: Oh absolutely. I'm like everybody else I guess that was Ellington fans at the time, although I was much younger and I didn't appreciate it in the '41, '42 era, but Ben Webster and Johnny Hodges are two of the musicians I could listen to until it's time to go, and when I go I want to take them with me. And so that sound of the Webster-Hodges connection in the '41, particularly the '41 band, is just a sound that as far as I'm concerned, nobody has ever been able to repeat.

MR: Did you have a chance to see them live a number of times?

DW: I saw the Ellington band live a number of times. I didn't see that band, I would have been only six years old.

MR: Someone made a famous quote about how Ellington could write, that he'd put three instruments together and no one could figure out what it was but him. Something like that.

DW: What an amazing man. You know as a teaching tool I often times ask students to think that if God were to give them a wish of being able to have an hour to spend with anybody that they could choose to spend that hour with, and the only condition is that you can't pick family, who would be the people you would pick to spend that one hour with? And Duke Ellington is at the top of my list. I would just love to have an hour with him, wouldn't you? Do an interview like this?

MR: From what I've read, he'd just charm the pants off you. He certainly had a gift of that too.

DW: He certainly did.

MR: As well as a composer. How often do you get out and do the film presentations?

DW: Well I started teaching these back home for various groups, whether it's a college, there is an African American college back home that wanted me to a history of jazz, African Americans on film in jazz. So I did a course on that. I teach for various churches and temples back home and I do a four hour class, four sessions, two hours each, of this new course which starts the last two Thursdays of this month and the first two Thursdays of next month. It's like from 7-9 and it's all on Ellington. So I have been researching Ellington and putting Ellington together, and I must have at least twelve classes full of material that I can't choose what I'm going to do. And I put it all together for this class, and now I've put so much together I don't know what I'm going to choose to share.

MR: Very hard to edit.

DW: Well I just don't know which are my favorites. There is so much. I've learned so much. You know you pick up little tidbits. Like I have a film where Nixon gives Ellington the Freedom Award. The highest award for a civilian, in a year or two, when Duke had been snubbed by the Pulitzer Prize Committee. So I have on film where Nixon invites him to the White House and gives him this award, and Duke kisses him two times on the right side and two times on the left side, and in the research I'm doing I learned that after the ceremony was over Duke said — Nixon said to Duke, "I'm not sure I understand the significance of the two kisses on each side; I know you go to Europe a lot and the tradition there is one kiss on each side. So what did this mean?" And The Duke, who has used this on numerous other occasions with women, said to the president, "Why Mr. President, that's one for each cheek." So it's now a story that I'm re-telling.

MR: Boy he was never at a loss for a line, was he? Well what do you think of this particular festival here at Sarasota?

DW: Well I love the festival. I've been disappointed with this year's edition, certainly not with the number of musicians and the wealth of their abilities, but I didn't think the first night clicked. I'm a Jazz at the Phil fan, it's one of my favorites. To be told that I'm going to get a chance to listen to jam session and then a ballad medley with all of these great artists, I would have expected a lot more. I just didn't think it gelled. It didn't come together for some reason. I'm not sure I know why, but I've been thinking about it ever since Wednesday night, and it just didn't come together. So I was disappointed in that. Last night I was very disappointed in the sound, which I think adversely affected The Statesmen, who I know to be a great group, and to see Benny Waters, 93 years young playing the horn better than most people can play at the age of 23, was just a thrill. But to have it all destroyed by the lack of the microphones being on or by the sound being too loud, was very discouraging. So last night I felt was a disappointing evening. The night in between those two nights I think was a great night, and I think the Count Basie Band will bring us all what we expect.

MR: I'm thinking of wearing neck brace, because I know they're going to take my head off when they hit that first chord, after hearing them this afternoon. You know I think someone could make a good living being a jazz sound man. I think that we have, I don't know if we've demanded over the years, to make things louder, but it seems they don't allow the musicians to set anything themselves somehow.

DW: Well I thought part of the problems last night was one of the musicians setting his own volume on his amp and that was the violin and he set it much, much too loud and I think his own age, in the 80s, almost 90, and his inability to hear like other people hear, may have affected it. I'm not sure but there's no excuse for an organization like this one to not have good sound. And I don't want to blame that on the musicians, I blame that on the professionals.

MR: Well I give these people credit. It's a big production. And sometimes pairing musicians can be a real dicey game, you know?

DW: Oh, very difficult, in fact that's one of the reasons the president of the Jazz Club here, who is a classmate of mine by the way and a good friend of mine, and one of the reasons I come here is because of him, but it's one of the main reasons he started delegating that to other people is that he just got so much grief by who he picked and who he didn't pick, that he turned it over to professionals like he did this year. But it does lose a little bit of the personal touch. I mean I've always liked at least in my own mind, to orchestrate my own festival. Who would I have if it were me?

MR: Well I think you should put on a festival.

DW: Well one of these days I might. But I do think there's a certain personal touch when I go to a festival and I know the people who have hand-selected the musicians and then I know I'm going to get what they like and what they like I would normally like or I wouldn't be there.

MR: One thing I have to say and we have spoken to quite a number of the musicians, and they almost without exception have so much dignity and class that it's really been inspiring. They have led great lives, certain times have been very difficult for them but boy they just have a lot of dignity.

DW: Well it's really true. You're point is very much well taken. And I remember the day in the '50s when jazz musicians left the United States because people here didn't appreciate them. And they had to go to Europe where they were much more appreciated. In fact I was stationed in Europe wearing an Army uniform and had to listen to jazz there in Germany where thousands of people gave standing ovation to the same musicians who were receiving nothing in the way of appreciation back home, and how sad it was I thought that our musicians had to go to Europe to be appreciated. Some of course decided to stay because they didn't like the way they were being treated because of their color or because they had chosen to become jazz musicians. So it was a very sad period. But today I agree with you. I talk to these musicians and there's not one of them that's not willing to share his time and his thoughts and they're classy, professional people who really enjoy what they do and if you happen to enjoy it just a little bit as much as they then they're pleased. They certainly don't do it for the money, because they don't get well paid.

MR: Well it's been an inspiration to talk to them. And I'm glad to see that some of the younger musicians like Christian McBride, in addition to doing his own thing, you know he grew up on James Brown, but he recognizes what has come before him and on his first solo record he brings in Ray Brown and Milt Hinton to do a bass trio. I love to see that.

DW: I thought it was very interesting that he did that because it was his way of sharing with the masters, his teacher. And they in turn will do that with him. It's just an American original art form music. I mean I don't know how else to better sum it up. Jazz is America's original art form music. Classical music isn't, rock & roll isn't, country music isn't. Jazz is America's original art form music.

MR: Well I can't think of a better way to wrap this conversation up.

DW: Well I can think of one better way, and that is to thank you for what you're doing. Because I think to do this for the students that are going to benefit from this in the years ahead, is wonderful, and I think you all are setting a good example for other institutions and I appreciate what you're doing.

MR: All right. Well on behalf of Hamilton College, I want to thank Don Wolff for his time and we're off to enjoy some music with the Basie Band and Joe Williams.

DW: Let's do it.

MR: Thanks so much.

DW: You're welcome.